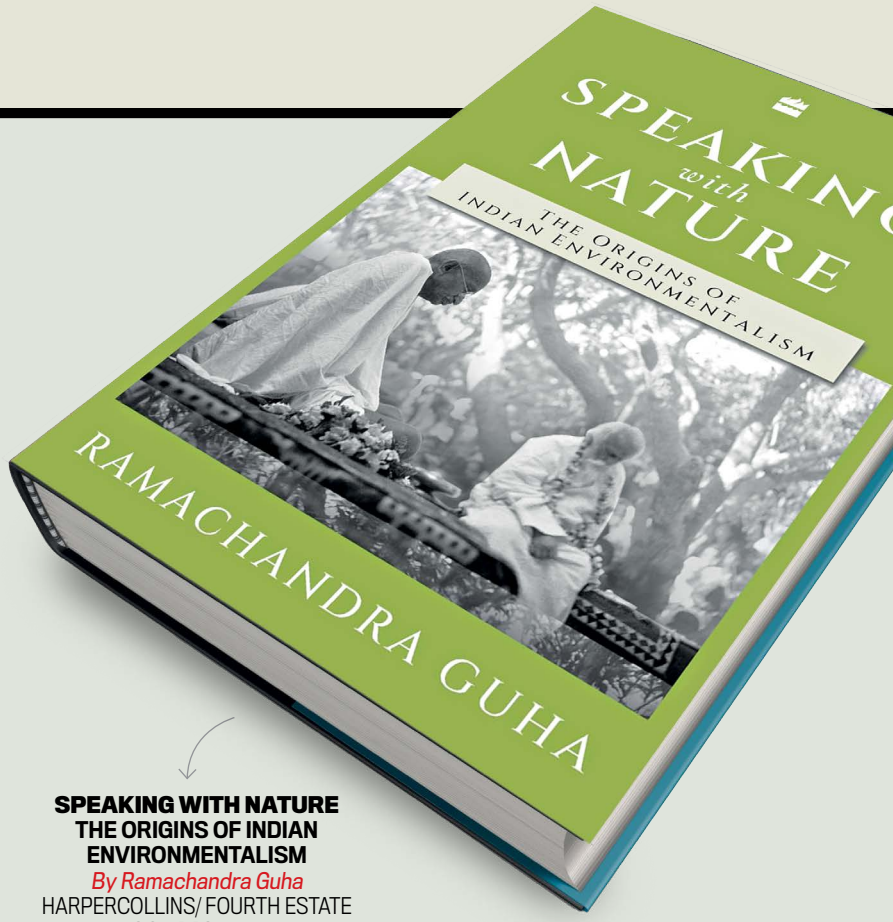
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SPEAKING WITH NATURE
THE ORIGINS OF INDIAN ENVIRONMENTALISM
By Ramachandra Guha
HARPERCOLLINS/ FOURTH ESTATE
₹799; 440 pages

"The environmental crisis India faces is greater than the crisis of political corruption or even of caste and communal conflict," says Ramachandra Guha. Our preoccupation with climate change, he worries, distracts from more pressing ecological concerns.

India faces severe environmental challenges like air pollution, groundwater depletion, soil contamination, dying rivers, and forest degradation. While climate change can worsen these, they primarily result from domestic policies and attitudes. Guha criticises the tendency to dismiss environmental concerns as a western conspiracy against the Global South. "It's true that the West is hypocritical," he argues, "but these problems are caused by our government, our industry, our people, our laws."

Although influential economists dismiss resistance to development as a "frivolous luxury" that poor nations can ill afford, history suggests otherwise. In the 19th century, the industrial revolution introduced technologies leading to environmental damage, raising questions about sustainable political systems, technologies and laws. Environmental movements in the Global North emerged from awareness of widespread degradation, while in the Global South, they were driven by ecological threats and the denial of livelihood rights.

The western response, led by Americans like Henry David Thoreau and John Muir, dominated the global discourse and climaxed with Rachel Carson's *Silent Spring*. However, its parallel in India that unfolded over the last century, with its nuances of colonialism and caste, has not been given its due. *Speaking with Nature: The Origins of Indian Environmentalism* makes an assertive stride to bridge that chasm. It also leaves us wondering about the costs and consequences of our indifference to history.

THE BOOK HAS SKETCHES OF FOREIGNERS WHO GAVE BACK TO INDIA—PATRICK GEDDES, VERRIER ELWIN AND MIRA BEHN

"As a historian," Guha says, "I have always believed that one should not predict or prescribe, but it's good to know how people have thought about these issues for a long time. So, this is a history of ideas."

To represent its breadth, Guha selected 10 pioneers—a "group portrait" of various strains of environmentalism. His book identifies their contributions in an Indian framework that speaks to the world, traces their persuasions and influences, and links their ideas and legacies.

For instance, few commentators have acknowledged Rabindranath Tagore's astute foresight in bringing environmental education to the curricula of schools he established in Bengal. Guha also profiles Radhakamal Mukerjee, the maverick economist whose research in Bengal of the 1920s identified the economic and ecological sustainability of natural resources small, local communities shared. A notable account is of K.M. Munshi, who became Nehru's agriculture minister by chance. He combined his enthusiasm for Hindu epics with the initiation of large-scale tree-planting festivals, which aligned with Hindutva ideology but lacked scientific moorings. Perhaps the most poignant profile is of J.C. Kumarappa,